

THE WORLD IN A VILLAGE



CULTURAL EXPERIENCE NINASAM, KARNATAKA

K S RAJARAM



"WE WANT FARMERS, TEACHERS EVERYONE TO SHARE A PLATFORM WITH ARTISTES."

K.V. AKSHARA, HEAD, NINASAM

It's easy to miss the tiny hamlet of Heggodu, but not in the first week of October, when more than 500 people gather for the annual culture course at Ninasam. "The idea of the course is to demystify the concepts of academics," says K.V. Akshara, the head of the institution. "We want everyone to engage with artistes and intellectuals like S.G. Vasudev and Ashis Nandy." There are daily shows of experimental theatre, dance and music, as well as world cinema. The performances are deconstructed the next day with participants ranging from critics like Sadanand Menon to school teachers from Malnad. Founded 50 years ago by Magsaysay award winner, the late K.V. Subbanna, Ninasam has slowly changed local aesthetic sensibilities, with local farmers giving the critics a run for their money in discussions on post-colonial literature. **by Nirmala Ravindran**



FIVE-STAR ASCETICISM



AYURVEDA TREATMENT

KALARI KOVILAKAM, KERALA

Imagine a vacation resort where you cannot touch your favourite wine or meat but must compulsorily put up with tulsi tea and papaya for breakfast, lentils and buttermilk for lunch and rice gruel and curry leaf-chutney for dinner. Where you are barred from stepping out till the mandatory 14-day stay ends. This penitentiary vacation at Kalari Kovilakam in Kollengode hardly comes cheap at Rs 4.14-9.21 lakh. But wellness enthusiasts from abroad have been arriving in droves and happily subject themselves to the rigours of the course. Says Nancy Freeman, 65,

an American businesswoman, "Been here for just one week, my blood pressure is at an all-time low and I have gotten out of my pills for the first time in two decades." Located in a 19th century palace in the foothills of the Western Ghats, Kalari occupies the middle ground between an ashram and a luxury resort. Says Cherry Cherian, Kalari's general manager, "Our speciality is providing ayurveda in an environment of international quality." No wonder the *New York Times* called the resort, "the land of four-star asceticism"!

by M.G. Radhakrishnan